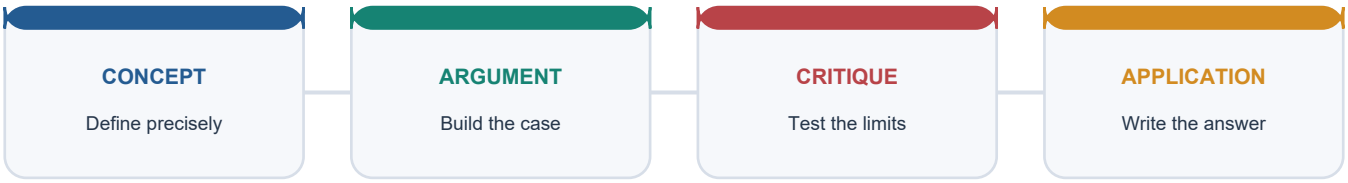
SOLVED PRACTICE WORKBOOK

Administration, Economy & Society under the Sultanate - Solved Practice Workbook

UPSC complete learning session | Foundation to advanced | Concepts, evidence, practice and answer writing

LEARNING PATH



Deterministic fallback visual: move from precise concepts through argument and critique to exam application.

Source order: repository knowledge -> official current linkage -> clearly marked analysis. No fabricated PYQs or statistics.

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Administration, Economy & Society under the Sultanate - Solved Practice Workbook

BASIC MCQS / REMEDIATION

Workbook MCQ 01

Question: Which phrase most accurately describes the Delhi Sultanate?

- A. A Persianate military-fiscal state whose central claims depended on negotiation below.
- B. A purely spiritual caliphate run from Baghdad.
- C. A society without villages or intermediaries.
- D. A timeless nation-state with fixed ministries.

Answer: A.

Explanation: The best phrase joins ideology, coercion and agrarian mediation.

Option-wise explanation:

- A. **Correct.** The best phrase joins ideology, coercion and agrarian mediation.
- B. **Incorrect.** "A purely spiritual caliphate run from Baghdad." runs into the topic trap: do not remove villages and intermediaries from the definition of the Sultanate.
- C. **Incorrect.** "A society without villages or intermediaries." misreads the evidence; the best phrase joins ideology, coercion and agrarian mediation.
- D. **Incorrect.** "A timeless nation-state with fixed ministries." falls once you remember that do not remove villages and intermediaries from the definition of the Sultanate.

Trap: Do not remove villages and intermediaries from the definition of the Sultanate.

Workbook MCQ 02

Question: Why is the phrase 'Persianate' useful in Topic 07?

- A. Because Persianate culture abolished local languages.
- B. Because it captures a transregional language-administrative culture that could include rulers and officials of varied origins.
- C. Because only Persian literature mattered in the Sultanate.
- D. Because all rulers were ethnically Persian.

Answer: B.

Explanation: The term is cultural-political, not ethnic.

Option-wise explanation:

- A. **Incorrect.** "Because Persianate culture abolished local languages." cannot stand because persianate is a cultural-administrative descriptor, not an ethnic label.
- B. **Correct.** The term is cultural-political, not ethnic.
- C. **Incorrect.** "Because only Persian literature mattered in the Sultanate." is too blunt for this topic; persianate is a cultural-administrative descriptor, not an ethnic label.
- D. **Incorrect.** "Because all rulers were ethnically Persian." misses what the evidence actually shows: the term is cultural-political, not ethnic.

Trap: Persianate is a cultural-administrative descriptor, not an ethnic label.

Workbook MCQ 03

Question: What made Delhi important beyond military conquest?

- A. It mattered only after the Mughals.
- B. It had no link with monetisation.
- C. Coinage, chancery, migrant scholars, court ritual and revenue coordination reinforced its centrality.
- D. It was the only town in north India.

Answer: C.

Explanation: Delhi became a nodal political and cultural centre, not just a fort.

Option-wise explanation:

- A. **Incorrect.** "It mattered only after the Mughals." overstates the case; delhi's centrality was institutional and monetary, not merely geographic.
- B. **Incorrect.** "It had no link with monetisation." is ruled out by the fact that delhi became a nodal political and cultural centre, not just a fort.
- C. **Correct.** Delhi became a nodal political and cultural centre, not just a fort.
- D. **Incorrect.** "It was the only town in north India." strips away the nuance that delhi became a nodal political and cultural centre, not just a fort.

Trap: Delhi's centrality was institutional and monetary, not merely geographic.

Workbook MCQ 04

Question: Which statement about succession under the Sultanate is safest?

- A. Primogeniture operated without interruption.
- B. Caliphal appointment automatically settled succession.
- C. Village panchayats chose the sultan.
- D. Nomination, noble acceptance, military strength and household politics all shaped succession.

Answer: D.

Explanation: This defeats simplistic dynastic assumptions.

Option-wise explanation:

- A. **Incorrect.** "Primogeniture operated without interruption." does not fit the source-based line here; this defeats simplistic dynastic assumptions.
- B. **Incorrect.** "Caliphal appointment automatically settled succession." confuses the issue because succession was negotiated and force-backed, not a clean primogeniture rule.
- C. **Incorrect.** "Village panchayats chose the sultan." sounds neat, but this defeats simplistic dynastic assumptions.
- D. **Correct.** This defeats simplistic dynastic assumptions.

Trap: Succession was negotiated and force-backed, not a clean primogeniture rule.

Workbook MCQ 05

Question: Why should Diwan-i-Risalat be handled cautiously?

- A. Because its exact portfolio is reconstructed differently by scholars and may shift across reigns.
- B. Because it only managed artillery.
- C. Because it was a Mughal-only innovation.
- D. Because the office certainly never existed.

Answer: A.

Explanation: Terminology caution itself is a mark of strong historical method.

Option-wise explanation:

- A. **Correct.** Terminology caution itself is a mark of strong historical method.
- B. **Incorrect.** "Because it only managed artillery." runs into the topic trap: handle Diwan-i-Risalat with chronology-and-portfolio caution.
- C. **Incorrect.** "Because it was a Mughal-only innovation." misreads the evidence; terminology caution itself is a mark of strong historical method.
- D. **Incorrect.** "Because the office certainly never existed." falls once you remember that handle Diwan-i-Risalat with chronology-and-portfolio caution.

Trap: Handle Diwan-i-Risalat with chronology-and-portfolio caution.

Workbook MCQ 06

Question: What was the political use of the barid network?

- A. It replaced the military department entirely.
- B. It carried intelligence upward and helped rulers watch governors, nobles and markets.
- C. It minted copper jitals.
- D. It managed Hindu temple endowments only.

Answer: B.

Explanation: Information was a technology of rule.

Option-wise explanation:

- A. **Incorrect.** "It replaced the military department entirely." cannot stand because barid means surveillance and reporting, not minting or military command.
- B. **Correct.** Information was a technology of rule.
- C. **Incorrect.** "It minted copper jitals." is too blunt for this topic; barid means surveillance and reporting, not minting or military command.
- D. **Incorrect.** "It managed Hindu temple endowments only." misses what the evidence actually shows: information was a technology of rule.

Trap: Barid means surveillance and reporting, not minting or military command.

Workbook MCQ 07

Question: Which social group is most directly linked to village headship in Topic 07's core evidence?

- A. Barids.
- B. Mir bakhshis.
- C. Muqaddams and related local landed intermediaries.
- D. Caliphal envoys.

Answer: C.

Explanation: Village headship belongs to local agrarian hierarchy.

Option-wise explanation:

- A. **Incorrect.** "Barids." overstates the case; keep village headship terms separate from imperial offices.
- B. **Incorrect.** "Mir bakhshis." is ruled out by the fact that village headship belongs to local agrarian hierarchy.
- C. **Correct.** Village headship belongs to local agrarian hierarchy.
- D. **Incorrect.** "Caliphal envoys." strips away the nuance that village headship belongs to local agrarian hierarchy.

Trap: Keep village headship terms separate from imperial offices.

Workbook MCQ 08

Question: Why is iqta not equivalent to European feudalism?

- A. Because Europe had no cavalry.
- B. Because iqta was a maritime customs office.
- C. Because iqta had no connection at all with revenue.
- D. Because the Sultanate state's superior claim, transfer power and audit logic differ from a simple proprietary-vassal model.

Answer: D.

Explanation: The comparison is useful only when its limits are stated.

Option-wise explanation:

- A. **Incorrect.** "Because Europe had no cavalry." does not fit the source-based line here; the comparison is useful only when its limits are stated.
- B. **Incorrect.** "Because iqta was a maritime customs office." confuses the issue because iqta is not shorthand for feudal private property.
- C. **Incorrect.** "Because iqta had no connection at all with revenue." sounds neat, but the comparison is useful only when its limits are stated.
- D. **Correct.** The comparison is useful only when its limits are stated.

Trap: Iqta is not shorthand for feudal private property.

Workbook MCQ 09

Question: What does khalisa most clearly indicate?

- A. Revenue reserved for more direct crown collection and visibility.
- B. The village police post.
- C. A type of slave corps.
- D. A class of urban merchants.

Answer: A.

Explanation: Khalisa is central to any discussion of Alauddin or crown finance.

Option-wise explanation:

- A. **Correct.** Khalisa is central to any discussion of Alauddin or crown finance.
- B. **Incorrect.** "The village police post." runs into the topic trap: khalisa means crown-held revenue, not a social group or office.
- C. **Incorrect.** "A type of slave corps." misreads the evidence; khalisa is central to any discussion of Alauddin or crown finance.
- D. **Incorrect.** "A class of urban merchants." falls once you remember that khalisa means crown-held revenue, not a social group or office.

Trap: Khalisa means crown-held revenue, not a social group or office.

Workbook MCQ 10

Question: Which ruler most clearly combined price regulation with military horse inspection?

- A. Raziya Sultan.
- B. Alauddin Khalji.
- C. Babur.
- D. Khizr Khan Sayyid.

Answer: B.

Explanation: Dagh and chehra must be placed correctly.

Option-wise explanation:

- A. **Incorrect.** "Raziya Sultan." cannot stand because link Alauddin's horse controls to military-fiscal supervision, not to modern state analogies.
- B. **Correct.** Dagh and chehra must be placed correctly.
- C. **Incorrect.** "Babur." is too blunt for this topic; link Alauddin's horse controls to military-fiscal supervision, not to modern state analogies.
- D. **Incorrect.** "Khizr Khan Sayyid." misses what the evidence actually shows: dagh and chehra must be placed correctly.

Trap: Link Alauddin's horse controls to military-fiscal supervision, not to modern state analogies.

Workbook MCQ 11

Question: Which statement about Muhammad bin Tughlaq is safest for Topic 07?

- A. He ruled only Delhi and Palam.
- B. He had no interest in caliphal legitimacy.
- C. He pushed centralisation, cash demand and recruitment widening further than his predecessors, but strained compliance and trust.
- D. He abolished monetisation.

Answer: C.

Explanation: The strongest line explains ambition and breakdown together.

Option-wise explanation:

- A. **Incorrect.** "He ruled only Delhi and Palam." overstates the case; muhammad bin Tughlaq is over-centralising and experimental, not territorially insignificant.
- B. **Incorrect.** "He had no interest in caliphal legitimacy." is ruled out by the fact that the strongest line explains ambition and breakdown together.
- C. **Correct.** The strongest line explains ambition and breakdown together.
- D. **Incorrect.** "He abolished monetisation." strips away the nuance that the strongest line explains ambition and breakdown together.

Trap: Muhammad bin Tughlaq is over-centralising and experimental, not territorially insignificant.

Workbook MCQ 12

Question: Why does Firuz matter in Topic 07?

- A. He removed all slave institutions.
- B. He invented the iqta from nothing.
- C. He abandoned public works entirely.
- D. He softened audit, encouraged heredity, expanded canals and workshops, and sharpened some juristic markers such as separate jizya.

Answer: D.

Explanation: Firuz's regime altered both welfare and hierarchy.

Option-wise explanation:

- A. **Incorrect.** "He removed all slave institutions." does not fit the source-based line here; firuz's regime altered both welfare and hierarchy.
- B. **Incorrect.** "He invented the iqta from nothing." confuses the issue because firuz matters for canals, heredity and conciliation-not for abolishing institutions.
- C. **Incorrect.** "He abandoned public works entirely." sounds neat, but firuz's regime altered both welfare and hierarchy.
- D. **Correct.** Firuz's regime altered both welfare and hierarchy.

Trap: Firuz matters for canals, heredity and conciliation-not for abolishing institutions.

Workbook MCQ 13

Question: What is the safest reading of jizya under the Sultanate?

- A. It mattered politically and symbolically, but it should not stand in for the totality of Hindu-Muslim social relations.
- B. It proves that all policy was only religious.
- C. It was absent from all Sultanate history.
- D. It was always completely separate from land demand from the first day.

Answer: A.

Explanation: The tax has to be placed in a broader fiscal and political field.

Option-wise explanation:

- A. **Correct.** The tax has to be placed in a broader fiscal and political field.
- B. **Incorrect.** "It proves that all policy was only religious." runs into the topic trap: do not let jizya swallow the whole social history of the Sultanate.
- C. **Incorrect.** "It was absent from all Sultanate history." misreads the evidence; the tax has to be placed in a broader fiscal and political field.
- D. **Incorrect.** "It was always completely separate from land demand from the first day." falls once you remember that do not let jizya swallow the whole social history of the Sultanate.

Trap: Do not let jizya swallow the whole social history of the Sultanate.

Workbook MCQ 14

Question: What best explains the growth of hundis?

- A. The end of road travel.
- B. Long-distance trade, credit needs and the work of money-changers and financiers across regions.
- C. The replacement of silver coins by cowries in Delhi.
- D. A ban on merchant initiative.

Answer: B.

Explanation: Hundis belong to commercial and financial integration.

Option-wise explanation:

- A. **Incorrect.** "The end of road travel." cannot stand because hundi belongs to credit and remittance, not to cowry myths or road collapse.
- B. **Correct.** Hundis belong to commercial and financial integration.
- C. **Incorrect.** "The replacement of silver coins by cowries in Delhi." is too blunt for this topic; hundi belongs to credit and remittance, not to cowry myths or road collapse.
- D. **Incorrect.** "A ban on merchant initiative." misses what the evidence actually shows: hundis belong to commercial and financial integration.

Trap: Hundi belongs to credit and remittance, not to cowry myths or road collapse.

Workbook MCQ 15

Question: Which commodity cluster best captures long-distance Sultanate trade?

- A. Only rice and wheat outward from every region.
- B. Only temple icons and paper outward.
- C. Textiles outward; horses, high-grade cloth and select goods inward.
- D. Only war booty outward and nothing inward.

Answer: C.

Explanation: Textiles remained India's most important manufacturing strength.

Option-wise explanation:

- A. **Incorrect.** "Only rice and wheat outward from every region." overstates the case; remember the core trade pair: textiles out, horses and select high-value goods in.
- B. **Incorrect.** "Only temple icons and paper outward." is ruled out by the fact that textiles remained India's most important manufacturing strength.
- C. **Correct.** Textiles remained India's most important manufacturing strength.
- D. **Incorrect.** "Only war booty outward and nothing inward." strips away the nuance that textiles remained India's most important manufacturing strength.

Trap: Remember the core trade pair: textiles out, horses and select high-value goods in.

Workbook MCQ 16

Question: What is the safest claim about artisans under the Sultanate?

- A. They disappeared after market regulation.
- B. They were all state slaves.
- C. They were all village serfs with no urban presence.
- D. They worked in towns and villages, in independent settings and in state-linked workshops, under unequal social conditions.

Answer: D.

Explanation: Craft life was varied and often poorly documented.

Option-wise explanation:

- A. **Incorrect.** "They disappeared after market regulation." does not fit the source-based line here; craft life was varied and often poorly documented.
- B. **Incorrect.** "They were all state slaves." confuses the issue because artisans worked across town and countryside under unequal conditions.
- C. **Incorrect.** "They were all village serfs with no urban presence." sounds neat, but craft life was varied and often poorly documented.
- D. **Correct.** Craft life was varied and often poorly documented.

Trap: Artisans worked across town and countryside under unequal conditions.

Workbook MCQ 17

Question: How should the spinning wheel be used in an answer?

- A. As evidence of technological diffusion and textile efficiency, with chronology caution and social-effect analysis.
- B. As irrelevant to cloth production.
- C. As proof that every household became prosperous.
- D. As a guaranteed twelfth-century Indian invention with exact first date.

Answer: A.

Explanation: Technology claims need both mechanism and caution.

Option-wise explanation:

- A. **Correct.** Technology claims need both mechanism and caution.
- B. **Incorrect.** "As irrelevant to cloth production." runs into the topic trap: use the spinning wheel for diffusion-plus-effect, not for invention myths.
- C. **Incorrect.** "As proof that every household became prosperous." misreads the evidence; technology claims need both mechanism and caution.
- D. **Incorrect.** "As a guaranteed twelfth-century Indian invention with exact first date." falls once you remember that use the spinning wheel for diffusion-plus-effect, not for invention myths.

Trap: Use the spinning wheel for diffusion-plus-effect, not for invention myths.

Workbook MCQ 18

Question: Why is the term 'urban revolution' debated?

- A. Because the debate concerns only architecture.
- B. Because town growth, crafts and monetisation were real, yet they rested on coercive extraction and uneven benefit.
- C. Because only European trade created Indian towns.
- D. Because no towns existed at all.

Answer: B.

Explanation: This is one of Topic 07's major historiographical axes.

Option-wise explanation:

- A. **Incorrect.** "Because the debate concerns only architecture." cannot stand because urban growth was real, but the debate survives because its gains were uneven.
- B. **Correct.** This is one of Topic 07's major historiographical axes.
- C. **Incorrect.** "Because only European trade created Indian towns." is too blunt for this topic; urban growth was real, but the debate survives because its gains were uneven.
- D. **Incorrect.** "Because no towns existed at all." misses what the evidence actually shows: this is one of Topic 07's major historiographical axes.

Trap: Urban growth was real, but the debate survives because its gains were uneven.

Workbook MCQ 19

Question: What is the safest interpretation of ashraf-ajlaf language?

- A. It replaces all regional and occupational distinctions.
- B. It proves perfect class equality among Muslims.
- C. It signals social differentiation within Muslim society, but its use needs chronology and source caution.
- D. It is a fixed fourteenth-century bureaucratic census category everywhere.

Answer: C.

Explanation: The labels are real and useful, but not timeless.

Option-wise explanation:

- A. **Incorrect.** "It replaces all regional and occupational distinctions." overstates the case; ashraf-ajlaf language requires chronology caution every time.
- B. **Incorrect.** "It proves perfect class equality among Muslims." is ruled out by the fact that the labels are real and useful, but not timeless.
- C. **Correct.** The labels are real and useful, but not timeless.
- D. **Incorrect.** "It is a fixed fourteenth-century bureaucratic census category everywhere." strips away the nuance that the labels are real and useful, but not timeless.

Trap: Ashraf-ajlaf language requires chronology caution every time.

Workbook MCQ 20

Question: Which statement best captures the position of Hindus under the Sultanate?

- A. All Hindus were treated identically across all reigns.
- B. Hindu society vanished from the countryside.
- C. No Hindu served any state function.
- D. They were not simply excluded: chiefs, peasants, merchants, soldiers, accountants and managers all remained important, amid conflict and hierarchy.

Answer: D.

Explanation: The strongest answer combines cooperation and coercion.

Option-wise explanation:

- A. **Incorrect.** "All Hindus were treated identically across all reigns." does not fit the source-based line here; the strongest answer combines cooperation and coercion.
- B. **Incorrect.** "Hindu society vanished from the countryside." confuses the issue because do not describe Hindus as a uniformly excluded or uniformly treated bloc.
- C. **Incorrect.** "No Hindu served any state function." sounds neat, but the strongest answer combines cooperation and coercion.
- D. **Correct.** The strongest answer combines cooperation and coercion.

Trap: Do not describe Hindus as a uniformly excluded or uniformly treated bloc.

Workbook MCQ 21

Question: Why is conversion a poor master-explanation for Sultanate society?

- A. Because social history also turns on landed power, towns, labour, language, courts, trade and everyday negotiation.
- B. Because conversions alone explain every town and market.
- C. Because conversions never happened.
- D. Because only rulers converted.

Answer: A.

Explanation: Conversion matters, but it is not the only explanatory engine.

Option-wise explanation:

- A. **Correct.** Conversion matters, but it is not the only explanatory engine.
- B. **Incorrect.** "Because conversions alone explain every town and market." runs into the topic trap: conversion is one process within society, not the master-key to all of it.
- C. **Incorrect.** "Because conversions never happened." misreads the evidence; conversion matters, but it is not the only explanatory engine.
- D. **Incorrect.** "Because only rulers converted." falls once you remember that conversion is one process within society, not the master-key to all of it.

Trap: Conversion is one process within society, not the master-key to all of it.

Workbook MCQ 22

Question: What is the best distinction between bandagan and wider slavery?

- A. Bandagan were simply village tenants.
- B. Bandagan were elite household military slaves with training and office prospects, unlike most domestic or captive slaves.
- C. Bandagan were Mughal revenue clerks.
- D. Bandagan were identical to all slaves in law and social effect.

Answer: B.

Explanation: This is a crucial conceptual distinction in Topic 07.

Option-wise explanation:

- A. **Incorrect.** "Bandagan were simply village tenants." cannot stand because bandagan are a special elite-slave formation, not a synonym for all slavery.
- B. **Correct.** This is a crucial conceptual distinction in Topic 07.
- C. **Incorrect.** "Bandagan were Mughal revenue clerks." is too blunt for this topic; bandagan are a special elite-slave formation, not a synonym for all slavery.
- D. **Incorrect.** "Bandagan were identical to all slaves in law and social effect." misses what the evidence actually shows: this is a crucial conceptual distinction in Topic 07.

Trap: Bandagan are a special elite-slave formation, not a synonym for all slavery.

Workbook MCQ 23

Question: How should purdah be described?

- A. As absent from all medieval India.
- B. As identical among every caste and class.
- C. As a stronger upper-class and courtly norm that spread unevenly; not as a universal practice for all women in all regions.
- D. As a Sultanate law imposed successfully on everyone.

Answer: C.

Explanation: Gender answers need class and region built in.

Option-wise explanation:

- A. **Incorrect.** "As absent from all medieval India." overstates the case; purdah spread unevenly and most strongly among upper groups.
- B. **Incorrect.** "As identical among every caste and class." is ruled out by the fact that gender answers need class and region built in.
- C. **Correct.** Gender answers need class and region built in.
- D. **Incorrect.** "As a Sultanate law imposed successfully on everyone." strips away the nuance that gender answers need class and region built in.

Trap: Purdah spread unevenly and most strongly among upper groups.

Workbook MCQ 24

Question: Which statement about education is safest?

- A. Persian replaced every other language immediately.
- B. Only royal princes were educated.
- C. Paper-making ended manuscript culture.
- D. Maktabs, madrasas, mosques, khanqahs, Sanskrit learning and practical multilingualism coexisted.

Answer: D.

Explanation: Knowledge institutions were multiple, not singular.

Option-wise explanation:

- A. **Incorrect.** "Persian replaced every other language immediately." does not fit the source-based line here; knowledge institutions were multiple, not singular.
- B. **Incorrect.** "Only royal princes were educated." confuses the issue because education remained plural and multilingual under the Sultanate.
- C. **Incorrect.** "Paper-making ended manuscript culture." sounds neat, but knowledge institutions were multiple, not singular.
- D. **Correct.** Knowledge institutions were multiple, not singular.

Trap: Education remained plural and multilingual under the Sultanate.

Workbook MCQ 25

Question: Why are Persian-knowing Hindus important for Topic 07?

- A. They show that administrative culture could expand across community lines without erasing hierarchy.
- B. They prove Persian ceased to dominate administration.
- C. They prove caste disappeared.
- D. They were only nineteenth-century phenomena.

Answer: A.

Explanation: Language competence created new service niches.

Option-wise explanation:

- A. **Correct.** Language competence created new service niches.
- B. **Incorrect.** "They prove Persian ceased to dominate administration." runs into the topic trap: persian-knowing Hindus show widening participation without erasing hierarchy.
- C. **Incorrect.** "They prove caste disappeared." misreads the evidence; language competence created new service niches.
- D. **Incorrect.** "They were only nineteenth-century phenomena." falls once you remember that persian-knowing Hindus show widening participation without erasing hierarchy.

Trap: Persian-knowing Hindus show widening participation without erasing hierarchy.

Workbook MCQ 26

Question: Which statement about Sufis in Topic 07 is safest?

- A. Topic 07 must ignore Sufis completely.
- B. They matter here mainly as part of social interaction and political context, while full movement ownership belongs to Topic 10.
- C. Sufis alone ran Sultanate law courts.
- D. All Sufis were anti-state in every setting.

Answer: B.

Explanation: Boundary discipline is part of a strong package.

Option-wise explanation:

- A. **Incorrect.** "Topic 07 must ignore Sufis completely." cannot stand because use Sufis here for interaction and context, not as a total substitute for Topic 10.
- B. **Correct.** Boundary discipline is part of a strong package.
- C. **Incorrect.** "Sufis alone ran Sultanate law courts." is too blunt for this topic; use Sufis here for interaction and context, not as a total substitute for Topic 10.
- D. **Incorrect.** "All Sufis were anti-state in every setting." misses what the evidence actually shows: boundary discipline is part of a strong package.

Trap: Use Sufis here for interaction and context, not as a total substitute for Topic 10.

Workbook MCQ 27

Question: How should temple destruction and patronage be framed in Topic 07?

- A. Every temple was always destroyed.
- B. The issue is irrelevant to social history.
- C. Episodes must be placed in political, military and local context rather than being flattened into a single civilisational formula.
- D. Every temple was always protected.

Answer: C.

Explanation: This avoids communal simplification while remaining evidence-led.

Option-wise explanation:

- A. **Incorrect.** "Every temple was always destroyed." overstates the case; temple evidence must be case-specific, never civilisationally flattened.
- B. **Incorrect.** "The issue is irrelevant to social history." is ruled out by the fact that this avoids communal simplification while remaining evidence-led.
- C. **Correct.** This avoids communal simplification while remaining evidence-led.
- D. **Incorrect.** "Every temple was always protected." strips away the nuance that this avoids communal simplification while remaining evidence-led.

Trap: Temple evidence must be case-specific, never civilisationally flattened.

Workbook MCQ 28

Question: What is the strongest way to read Barani?

- A. As useless because he was biased.
- B. As the only source that matters.
- C. As a perfectly neutral census reporter.
- D. As indispensable for elite ideology and policy language, but shaped by aristocratic prejudice and normative aims.

Answer: D.

Explanation: Good answers use Barani critically, not blindly.

Option-wise explanation:

- A. **Incorrect.** "As useless because he was biased." does not fit the source-based line here; good answers use Barani critically, not blindly.
- B. **Incorrect.** "As the only source that matters." confuses the issue because barani is indispensable because he is biased, not because he is neutral.
- C. **Incorrect.** "As a perfectly neutral census reporter." sounds neat, but good answers use Barani critically, not blindly.
- D. **Correct.** Good answers use Barani critically, not blindly.

Trap: Barani is indispensable because he is biased, not because he is neutral.

Workbook MCQ 29

Question: Why are coins valuable in Topic 07?

- A. They connect sovereignty, minting, monetisation and public claims without proving complete territorial control.
- B. They replace the need for all written sources.
- C. They show that all provinces used one fixed economy at all times.
- D. They reveal precise peasant income.

Answer: A.

Explanation: Coins are strong but bounded evidence.

Option-wise explanation:

- A. **Correct.** Coins are strong but bounded evidence.
- B. **Incorrect.** "They replace the need for all written sources." runs into the topic trap: coins prove claims and circulation, not complete control or full welfare data.
- C. **Incorrect.** "They show that all provinces used one fixed economy at all times." misreads the evidence; coins are strong but bounded evidence.
- D. **Incorrect.** "They reveal precise peasant income." falls once you remember that coins prove claims and circulation, not complete control or full welfare data.

Trap: Coins prove claims and circulation, not complete control or full welfare data.

Workbook MCQ 30

Question: Which statement about qanungo is safest?

- A. It was another name for the ariz.
- B. Use the term only with chronology caution; it is not a secure universal office for the early Sultanate local hierarchy.
- C. It is the normal office for every Mamluk village.
- D. It replaced the kotwal.

Answer: B.

Explanation: Administrative vocabulary must be time-bound.

Option-wise explanation:

- A. **Incorrect.** "It was another name for the ariz." cannot stand because never universalise qanungo backward into the whole early Sultanate.
- B. **Correct.** Administrative vocabulary must be time-bound.
- C. **Incorrect.** "It is the normal office for every Mamluk village." is too blunt for this topic; never universalise qanungo backward into the whole early Sultanate.
- D. **Incorrect.** "It replaced the kotwal." misses what the evidence actually shows: administrative vocabulary must be time-bound.

Trap: Never universalise qanungo backward into the whole early Sultanate.

Workbook MCQ 31

Question: What best captures Lodi politics from a Topic 07 perspective?

- A. The Lodis rejected all revenue supervision.
- B. The Lodis ended all iqta-like assignment structures overnight.
- C. Afghan claims of consultation and equality complicated but did not abolish monarchy or centralisation.
- D. The Lodis ruled only through Sufi shrines.

Answer: C.

Explanation: The Afghan angle is about elite bargaining, not statelessness.

Option-wise explanation:

- A. **Incorrect.** "The Lodis rejected all revenue supervision." overstates the case; lodi Afghan consultation complicated monarchy; it did not eliminate it.
- B. **Incorrect.** "The Lodis ended all iqta-like assignment structures overnight." is ruled out by the fact that the Afghan angle is about elite bargaining, not statelessness.
- C. **Correct.** The Afghan angle is about elite bargaining, not statelessness.
- D. **Incorrect.** "The Lodis ruled only through Sufi shrines." strips away the nuance that the Afghan angle is about elite bargaining, not statelessness.

Trap: Lodi Afghan consultation complicated monarchy; it did not eliminate it.

Workbook MCQ 32

Question: What is the safest one-line verdict on Sultanate society?

- A. It was fully modern or fully feudal with no middle ground.
- B. It changed nothing socially or economically.
- C. It can be summarised entirely by one tax term.
- D. The Sultanate combined centralising aspiration, negotiated enforcement and socially uneven outcomes.

Answer: D.

Explanation: This verdict is short, balanced and high-yield.

Option-wise explanation:

- A. **Incorrect.** "It was fully modern or fully feudal with no middle ground." does not fit the source-based line here; this verdict is short, balanced and high-yield.
- B. **Incorrect.** "It changed nothing socially or economically." confuses the issue because the safest verdict keeps inequality, interaction and change together.
- C. **Incorrect.** "It can be summarised entirely by one tax term." sounds neat, but this verdict is short, balanced and high-yield.
- D. **Correct.** This verdict is short, balanced and high-yield.

Trap: The safest verdict keeps inequality, interaction and change together.

Remediation map - predictable errors and their correcting Workbook MCQs

Predictable error	What it usually sounds like	Correcting Workbook MCQs
Treating the Sultanate as a finished modern state	"fixed ministries, nation-state, no local negotiation"	01, 03, 04
Confusing Persianate culture with ethnicity	"all rulers were Persians"	02, 25
Flattening iqta into feudal private property	"land ownership passed automatically and permanently"	08, 09, 31
Forgetting village intermediaries	"the court dealt directly with peasants everywhere"	07, 20

Predictable error	What it usually sounds like	Correcting Workbook MCQs
Using jizya as the whole story	"religion alone explains administration and society"	13, 20, 27
Turning market growth into universal prosperity	"trade meant equal gains for everyone"	14, 16, 18, 32
Writing technology as invention-list only	"name devices, skip users and effects"	17, 24
Ignoring internal Muslim differentiation	"Muslims formed one flat social bloc"	19, 32
Reducing conversion to one cause	"either sword only or saint only"	21, 26
Confusing elite military slavery with all slavery	"bandagan = every slave"	22, 32
Universalising elite gender norms	"purdah applied identically to all women"	23, 32
Over-trusting single court sources	"Barani alone proves the whole society"	28, 29
Projecting later offices backward	"qanungo everywhere from the start"	30, 07
Forgetting Afghan political distinctiveness	"Lodis simply copied earlier Turkish patterns"	31, 04

Rapid revision grid - phrase the objective answer correctly

Theme	Safe exam line	What to avoid	Linked Workbook MCQs
Nature of the state	A Persianate military-fiscal state whose central claims depended on negotiation below.	Nation-state analogies or Baghdad rule.	01, 31
Elite composition	Turkish dominance mattered early, but access widened through Khalji, Tughlaq and Afghan phases.	Treating Persianate as a racial label.	02, 05, 19
Central departments	Wizarat, Arz and Insha are the safest fixed anchors; other portfolios need reign-specific caution.	Projecting one reign's ministry chart across all centuries.	04, 30
Iqta	A transferable service-linked revenue assignment, not private ownership of land and peasants.	Calling it an indigenous or automatically hereditary estate.	08, 09
Provincial-local link	Muqtis, amils and pargana-level functionaries worked through khuts, muqaddams and chaudhuris.	Imagining direct court-to-peasant collection everywhere.	07, 20
Revenue terms	Fiscal labels are starting points; actual burden changed by place, reign and method of collection.	Treating jizya or kharaj as the whole social story.	10, 13, 27
Army and control	Cavalry strength depended on horses, branding, descriptive rolls and revenue backing.	Reading the Sultanate army through Mughal or modern categories.	11, 12
Agrarian change	Expansion, irrigation and extraction coexisted; no single prosperity line fits all regions.	Turning Firuz's canals into an all-India revolution.	14, 15
Towns, money and trade	Coins, hundis, sarrafs and trade routes linked agrarian surplus to urban growth.	Treating towns as detached from the countryside.	16, 18
Technology	Diffusion mattered through output, paperwork, irrigation, construction and cavalry support.	Writing a bare list of inventions without users or effects.	17, 24
Religion and society	Coexistence, conflict, patronage and conversion all need differentiated treatment.	Flat Hindu-Muslim binaries or one-cause conversion stories.	21, 26, 32

Theme	Safe exam line	What to avoid	Linked Workbook MCQs
Sources and method	Chronicles, travellers, coins and buildings must be cross-read by genre and limit.	Letting one court chronicler stand for the whole society.	28, 29
Kingship and law	Sharia, zawabit and reason of state interacted; none alone explains Sultanate governance.	Calling the polity purely secular or purely juristic.	03, 27
Caliphal legitimacy	Investiture and khutba mattered symbolically, but Delhi ruled through its own army, revenue and court.	Treating Baghdad as the actual government of India.	03, 30
Policing and justice	Kotwal, qazi, muhtasib and local custom formed a layered order, strongest in big towns.	Assuming one uniform legal machine in every district.	12, 29
Rural hierarchy	Khuts, muqaddams and chaudhuris were neither peasants in general nor sovereign chiefs beyond the state.	Flattening all countryside actors into one class.	07, 15, 20
Artisans and karkhanas	Production mixed independent artisans, merchant demand and state-linked workshops.	Turning every skilled worker into a state dependent.	16, 17, 22
Slavery and gender	Evidence is richest for elite households and courts; social practice below that level was uneven.	Universalising elite purdah or reading every slave as a bandagan commander.	22, 23, 32

Quick elimination drills - when two options look plausible

- If one option turns a **service-linked office** into **private property**, reject it first; Topic 07 repeatedly separates office, assignment and ownership.
- If a choice quietly imports a **Mughal title** such as *Mir Bakshi* into the Sultanate, test chronology before anything else.
- When a statement uses **all, every, only, fully** or **uniformly**, ask whether the topic evidence instead shows dynastic, regional or social variation.
- If a revenue statement sounds purely juristic, look for the missing question: **who actually paid, where, and under which ruler?**
- If an urban or trade option ignores **roads, sarais, brokers, horses, coin or credit**, it probably treats commerce too abstractly.
- If a technology option lists devices without naming **output, paperwork, irrigation, construction or military effect**, it is likely incomplete even when the noun list looks familiar.
- If a social statement erases differences among **Turks, Tajiks, Afghans, new Muslims, artisans, village heads or royal slaves**, it is flattening the evidence.
- If a source-based statement assumes a chronicle is a neutral mirror, bring in **genre, patronage and silence** before choosing it.

PYQS AND ANSWER PRACTICE

Verified and honestly-adjacent PYQs

Direct PYQ 01 - UPSC Prelims GS-I 2019 (directly relevant; exact wording verified locally)

Question: Consider the following statements:

1. In the revenue administration of Delhi Sultanate, the in-charge of revenue collection was known as "Amil".
2. The Iqta system of Sultans of Delhi was an ancient indigenous institution.
3. The office of "Mir Bakshi" came into existence during the reign of Khalji Sultans of Delhi.

Which of the statements given above is/are correct?

A. 1 only B. 1 and 2 only C. 3 only D. 1, 2 and 3

Inferred answer - not officially verified locally: 1 only. Confidence: high.

Model explanation: Statement 1 is correct because *amil* was the revenue-collection functionary at the relevant level. Statement 2 is incorrect because iqta had West and Central Asian antecedents before its Indian adaptation. Statement 3 is incorrect because *Mir Bakshi* belongs to the Mughal system; the Sultanate military department centred on the ariz and Diwan-i-Arz.

Why this earns marks: It tests statement-by-statement institutional placement and blocks both the indigenous-iqta myth and the Mughal-office projection trap.

Demand decoding: Treat "Consider the following statements: 1. In the revenue administration of Delhi Sultanate, the..." as a source-and-elimination problem: verify each statement independently, preserve the official wording where available, and separate an inferred key from an official key.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: Identify the tested chronology, site, text, inscription or institution; eliminate each option with one named fact; then state the evidence limit or key-verification status.

How to improve this answer: For "Consider the following statements: 1. In the revenue administration of Delhi Sultanate, the...", add one explicit sentence explaining why the closest distractor fails on chronology, geography, source class or degree of certainty.

Direct PYQ 02 - UPSC Prelims GS-I 2022 (directly relevant monetary-term question; exact wording verified locally)

Question: In medieval India, the term "Fanam" referred to:

A. Clothing B. Coins C. Ornaments D. Weapons

Inferred answer - not officially verified locally: Coins. Confidence: high.

Model explanation: *Fanam* was a coin term in medieval India, especially in wider south Indian and coastal circulation. The exact stem and options are locally recoverable from the 2022 official-paper text file, but the local repository does not preserve the official UPSC key row, so the answer remains honestly marked as inferred.

Why this earns marks: It tests lexical precision in medieval numismatics and blocks the trap of turning a coin term into a material-culture distractor.

Demand decoding: Treat the stem as a straightforward elimination problem in monetary terminology: identify *fanam* as coin-language, reject every non-numismatic option and state the official-key limit honestly.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: In Prelims, define the term in one phrase, reject each non-monetary option quickly and avoid over-explaining beyond the lexical identification.

How to improve this answer: Add one short contrast sentence linking *fanam* to wider medieval coin vocabulary such as tanka, jital or regional coastal circulation without pretending it was the only Sultanate coin in use.

Adjacent PYQ 03 - UPSC GS-I 2020 (directly relevant source-method question; wording preserved in repository)

Question: Persian literary sources of medieval India reflect the spirit of the age. Comment. (Answer in 250 words)

Model answer:

Persian literary sources are indispensable for medieval India because they preserve the language of sovereignty, conquest, justice, bureaucracy and courtly aspiration. Yet they reflect the spirit of the age only when read through

genre, patronage and silence.

For Topic 07 this is especially clear. Barani helps explain kingship, aristocratic prejudice, Alauddin's market measures and the tension between sharia and political expediency, but he is late, moralising and hostile to low-born advancement. Ibn Battuta illuminates roads, towns, gifts, punishments and products, yet his traveller's eye seeks the vivid rather than the statistically ordinary. Afif and Firuz's own *Futuhat* reveal how a ruler wished benevolence and piety to be seen. Coins, inscriptions and buildings in turn provide harder public claims, but not full social life.

Thus Persian sources do reflect the age - especially its elite political culture, administrative ambition and moral vocabulary - but not as neutral mirrors. They require comparison with material evidence, local structures and non-courtly social realities.

Why this earns marks: It comments on the word 'reflect' itself, names multiple source types and turns source bias into method rather than complaint.

Demand decoding: The directive **comment** requires a direct position on "Persian literary sources of medieval India reflect the spirit of the age. Comment. (Answer...", coverage of every clause, evidence-led analysis and a qualified verdict.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For a 15-mark answer, open with a two-sentence thesis; organise five named evidence units as claim -> evidence -> inference -> qualification; reserve the final lines for a graded conclusion.

How to improve this answer: For "Persian literary sources of medieval India reflect the spirit of the age. Comment. (Answer...", replace the weakest generalisation with one additional named site, text, inscription, coin, ruler or scholarly position and state exactly what that evidence cannot prove.

Adjacent PYQ 04 - UPSC Prelims GS-I 2022 (adjacent but useful frontier-institution question; exact wording verified locally)

Question: With reference to Indian history, consider the following statements:

1. The first Mongol invasion of India happened during the reign of Jalal-ud-din Khalji.
2. During the reign of Ala-ud-din Khalji, one Mongol assault marched up to Delhi and besieged the city.
3. Muhammad-bin-Tughlaq temporarily lost portions of north-west of his kingdom to Mongols.

Which of the statements given above is/are correct?

(a) 1 and 2 (b) 2 only (c) 1 and 3 (d) 3 only

Inferred answer - not officially verified locally: 2 only. Confidence: high.

Model explanation: Statement 1 is incorrect because Mongol pressure predates Jalaluddin Khalji. Statement 2 is correct because a major Mongol assault reached and besieged Delhi in Alauddin's time. Statement 3 is not secure in the form stated.

Why this earns marks: It is adjacent rather than core, but it sharpens the army-frontier chronology that any Topic 07 answer on cavalry finance and defence must keep straight.

Demand decoding: Treat "With reference to Indian history, consider the following statements: 1. The first Mongol..." as a source-and-elimination problem: verify each statement independently, preserve the official wording where available, and separate an inferred key from an official key.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: Identify the tested chronology, site, text, inscription or institution; eliminate each option with one named fact; then state the evidence limit or key-verification status.

How to improve this answer: For "With reference to Indian history, consider the following statements: 1. The first Mongol...", add one explicit sentence explaining why the closest distractor fails on chronology, geography, source class or degree of certainty.

Direct PYQ 05 - UPSC GS-I 2023 (directly relevant; wording preserved in repository)

Question: What were the major technological changes introduced during the Sultanate period? How did those technological changes influence the Indian society? (Answer in 250 words)

Model answer:

The Sultanate period witnessed important technological diffusion in textiles, record-keeping, irrigation, construction and military equipment. Their significance lay less in isolated invention than in **how they reshaped production, urban growth and state capacity**.

Paper-making widened the practical world of accounts, letters and manuscripts. The spinning wheel, cotton-carder's bow and improved looms strengthened textile production. Water-lifting devices and, in some regions, canal networks supported cultivation. Lime mortar, arches and domes enlarged the scale and durability of construction. Saddles, armour, stirrups and horse-management techniques mattered to cavalry warfare.

Social effect was uneven. Urban workshops, state offices, merchants and military systems benefited most. Artisans found new demand, but hierarchy persisted and slavery or low-wage labour remained embedded in production. Irrigation and construction enhanced elite and state power more than universal welfare.

Thus technological change under the Sultanate contributed to urbanisation, stronger administration, wider textile production and military organisation, while remaining filtered through social inequality.

Why this earns marks: It answers both parts, moves from devices to effects and avoids the trap of a bare technology list.

Demand decoding: The directive **answer** requires a direct position on "What were the major technological changes introduced during the Sultanate period? How did...", coverage of every clause, evidence-led analysis and a qualified verdict.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For a 15-mark answer, open with a two-sentence thesis; organise five named evidence units as claim -> evidence -> inference -> qualification; reserve the final lines for a graded conclusion.

How to improve this answer: For "What were the major technological changes introduced during the Sultanate period? How did...", replace the weakest generalisation with one additional named site, text, inscription, coin, ruler or scholarly position and state exactly what that evidence cannot prove.

PYQ verification ledger and scope honesty

- **Directly routed and solved:** 2019 Prelims revenue administration, 2022 Prelims Q52 on *fanam* monetary terminology, and 2023 GS-I Sultanate technology.
- **Adjacent but retained honestly:** 2020 GS-I Persian literary sources belongs to Topic 24, and 2022 Prelims GS-I Mongol chronology belongs to Topic 04 while remaining useful for Topic 07's frontier-military chronology.
- The 2019 and 2022 Prelims items are still labelled **Inferred answer - not officially verified locally** wherever the local repository preserves the official paper wording but not the official UPSC key row.
- No coaching-studio question and no optional-paper question has been relabelled as a UPSC PYQ.

Original solved Mains questions

Mains 01 - 10 marks

Question: Explain why the Delhi Sultanate is best described as a centralised apex resting on negotiated local power. Answer in 150 words.

Model answer:

The Delhi Sultanate built a visible central apex: the sultan distributed office and iqta, commanded the army, issued coinage, controlled chancery communication and projected justice. Departments such as the Wizarat, Arz and Insha show that rule had differentiated institutional form. Coins, khutba and court ceremonial further publicised sovereignty.

Yet this apex never operated in a social vacuum. Muqtis, amils, khuts, muqaddams, chaudhuris, patwaris, chiefs and merchants translated central claims into actual grain, cash, horses and obedience. Village structures were not erased; they were used. Even when Alauddin tightened khalisa control, he did not abolish local intermediaries. Firuz later softened audit and hereditary claims widened.

Thus the best formulation is that the Sultanate was centralised in aspiration and more centralised than many earlier regional monarchies, but it remained negotiated in implementation. Distance, ecology, faction and local landed strength limited uniform bureaucratic control.

Why this earns marks: It opens with a direct thesis, names institutions, explains the local mechanism, adds dynastic variation and ends with a balanced verdict.

Demand decoding: The directive **explain** requires a direct position on "Explain why the Delhi Sultanate is best described as a centralised apex resting on...", coverage of every clause, evidence-led analysis and a qualified verdict.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For a 10-mark answer, open with a two-sentence thesis; organise three named evidence units as claim -> evidence -> inference -> qualification; reserve the final lines for a graded conclusion.

How to improve this answer: For "Explain why the Delhi Sultanate is best described as a centralised apex resting on...", replace the weakest generalisation with one additional named site, text, inscription, coin, ruler or scholarly position and state exactly what that evidence cannot prove.

Mains 02 - 10 marks

Question: How did the iqta system function, and why should it not be equated with private property? Answer in 150 words.

Model answer:

The iqta was a fiscal-military assignment through which the sultan transferred the right to collect revenue from a tract to a muqti or wali in return for service, administration and troop maintenance. The holder preserved order, met authorised expenses and, in principle, answered to the centre for the balance due. Transfer, recall and audit were the key checks.

It should not be treated as private property because legal superiority remained with the state. The muqti did not own the soil, all peasants or an inherently hereditary estate. Practice differed across time: Mamluk rulers used iqta for consolidation, Alauddin tightened supervision in the core, Muhammad bin Tughlaq experimented with cash and revenue farming, and Firuz encouraged heredity and softer audit.

Therefore iqta was a service-linked revenue assignment whose meaning changed with political strength.

Why this earns marks: It defines the institution, shows mechanism, inserts chronology and blocks the standard property trap.

Demand decoding: The directive **answer** requires a direct position on "How did the iqta system function, and why should it not be equated with private property?...", coverage of every clause, evidence-led analysis and a qualified verdict.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For a 10-mark answer, open with a two-sentence thesis; organise three named evidence units as claim -> evidence -> inference -> qualification; reserve the final lines for a graded conclusion.

How to improve this answer: For "How did the iqta system function, and why should it not be equated with private property?...", replace the weakest generalisation with one additional named site, text, inscription, coin, ruler or scholarly position and state exactly what that evidence cannot prove.

Mains 03 - 15 marks

Question: Examine the relationship between monetisation, urbanisation and agrarian extraction under the Delhi Sultanate. Answer in 250 words.

Model answer:

The Delhi Sultanate's towns did not float free from the countryside. Monetisation and urbanisation expanded, but they did so through a military-fiscal system that drew agrarian surplus upward.

First, stable coinage - especially the silver tanka and copper jital - helped taxation, salary payment and market exchange. Second, a stronger central state improved roads, relays and sarais, allowing grain, cloth, horses and money to move between regions. Third, merchant finance through hundis, modis and sarrafs widened the reach of long-distance trade. Delhi, Lahore, Multan, Lakhnauti, Cambay and Sonargaon all grew through this interaction of state demand and commerce.

But the urban story cannot be separated from rural burden. Alauddin's core-zone extraction, Muhammad bin Tughlaq's harsh doab assessment and the dependence of iqta-holders on rural realisation show that towns and armies were

sustained by peasant production. Khuts, muqaddams and chiefs mediated this transfer and often protected their own position.

Hence growth and coercion must be read together. Urban revival was real - textiles, paper, metallurgy and trade flourished - yet much of that revival depended on unequal surplus extraction and elite consumption.

Why this earns marks: It links coinage, roads, finance and towns to the agrarian mechanism instead of narrating them separately.

Demand decoding: The directive **examine** requires a direct position on "Examine the relationship between monetisation, urbanisation and agrarian extraction under...", coverage of every clause, evidence-led analysis and a qualified verdict.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For a 15-mark answer, open with a two-sentence thesis; organise five named evidence units as claim -> evidence -> inference -> qualification; reserve the final lines for a graded conclusion.

How to improve this answer: For "Examine the relationship between monetisation, urbanisation and agrarian extraction under...", replace the weakest generalisation with one additional named site, text, inscription, coin, ruler or scholarly position and state exactly what that evidence cannot prove.

Mains 04 - 15 marks

Question: Assess the changing composition of the Sultanate nobility and its political consequences. Answer in 250 words.

Model answer:

The Sultanate nobility changed from an early concentration of Turks and military slaves to a wider, more contested elite including Persians, Khaljis, Afghans, Indian Muslims, converts and local allies. That widening mattered politically because it altered both opportunity and instability.

In the Mamluk phase, elite slavery and Turkish high-status claims gave the court a disciplined but narrow ruling circle. Barani's later contempt for low-born appointment reflects this older exclusionary ideal. Yet even early Delhi required Tajik administrators, Hindu accountants and local chiefs.

The Khalji phase widened access to office by weakening old Turkish monopoly. Alauddin's state needed talent and force more than pedigree alone. Muhammad bin Tughlaq widened recruitment further, appointing foreigners, new men and some Hindus to high office. This improved reach, but chroniclers portray intense aristocratic resentment. Firuz reversed course toward conciliation, high salaries and heredity, which reduced friction in the short run but narrowed discipline and hardened oligarchic interests. In the Lodi phase, Afghan notions of consultation complicated monarchical centralisation further.

Therefore, changing noble composition was not a background detail. It shaped succession, military command, revenue control and ideological conflict at the heart of the Sultanate.

Why this earns marks: It uses chronology, named source bias and political consequence rather than listing communities mechanically.

Demand decoding: The directive **assess** requires a direct position on "Assess the changing composition of the Sultanate nobility and its political consequences....", coverage of every clause, evidence-led analysis and a qualified verdict.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For a 15-mark answer, open with a two-sentence thesis; organise five named evidence units as claim -> evidence -> inference -> qualification; reserve the final lines for a graded conclusion.

How to improve this answer: For "Assess the changing composition of the Sultanate nobility and its political consequences....", replace the weakest generalisation with one additional named site, text, inscription, coin, ruler or scholarly position and state exactly what that evidence cannot prove.

Mains 05 - 20 marks

Question: 'The Delhi Sultanate was neither a uniform bureaucracy nor a timeless Islamic state.' Discuss. Answer in 250 words.

Model answer:

The statement is persuasive because it rejects two misleading simplifications at once. The Delhi Sultanate did develop differentiated institutions, but these never produced a uniform modern-style bureaucracy across all regions and reigns. Likewise, Islamic language and law mattered deeply, yet the state cannot be reduced to a timeless theocracy.

On the administrative side, the Sultanate had a clear central apex: the sultan, wazir, ariz, insha, qazi-sadr and barid network. Coinage, khutba, court ceremonial and iqta transfers demonstrate organised sovereignty. Yet implementation depended on muqtis, amils, khuts, muqaddams, chaudhuris, chiefs, merchants and village accountants. Terms such as shiq, pargana and zamindar must themselves be used chronologically and regionally. Alauddin's tighter supervision, Muhammad bin Tughlaq's over-centralising experiments, Firuz's hereditary drift and Lodi Afghan bargaining show that no single administrative diagram fits the whole period.

On the religious side, rulers invoked sharia, appointed qazis and ulema, and used caliphal or juristic idiom. But political expediency repeatedly supplemented formal law. Alauddin openly asserted reason of state; Muhammad bin Tughlaq mixed symbolic caliphal legitimacy with wider intellectual contact; Firuz moved toward sharper juristic display yet still governed through public works, compromise and material calculation. Non-Muslim communities retained their own social institutions and local law in many settings.

Thus the Sultanate is best read as a Persianate military-fiscal monarchy using Islamic legitimacy while ruling through negotiated, uneven and practical governance.

Why this earns marks: It answers both negations directly, organises the body into state and religion, and ends with a precise synthetic verdict.

Demand decoding: The directive **discuss** requires a direct position on "'The Delhi Sultanate was neither a uniform bureaucracy nor a timeless Islamic state.'...", coverage of every clause, evidence-led analysis and a qualified verdict.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For a 20-mark answer, open with a two-sentence thesis; organise six to eight named evidence units as claim -> evidence -> inference -> qualification; reserve the final lines for a graded conclusion.

How to improve this answer: For "'The Delhi Sultanate was neither a uniform bureaucracy nor a timeless Islamic state.'...", replace the weakest generalisation with one additional named site, text, inscription, coin, ruler or scholarly position and state exactly what that evidence cannot prove.

Mains 06 - 20 marks

Question: Evaluate the social consequences of technology diffusion, trade growth and labour hierarchy under the Delhi Sultanate. Answer in 250 words.

Model answer:

Technology diffusion and trade growth under the Delhi Sultanate reshaped production and exchange, but their social effects were filtered through hierarchy. Gains were real, yet unevenly distributed.

Wider use of the spinning wheel, cotton-carder's bow, improved looms, paper-making and construction techniques supported textiles, record-keeping and urban building. Water-lifting improvements and canals aided cultivation in some regions. Better roads, sarais, coins and credit widened long-distance exchange. Merchant groups such as Multanis, Gujaratis, Jains and Bohras worked with financiers and hundis to move goods and money.

These changes encouraged urbanisation and specialised craft activity. Delhi, Cambay and Sonargaon became centres of demand and exchange, while court consumption, army provisioning and merchant trade stimulated artisans in towns and villages.

Yet the gains were unequal. Peasants still bore heavy revenue pressure. Artisans often worked for low wages or in dependent conditions. Slavery remained embedded in elite society, and upper-status prejudice persisted among Hindu and Muslim elites. Purdah and social restriction spread most strongly among upper groups.

Therefore technology and trade expanded capability, but not social equality; they enlarged power and urban demand within a stratified order.

Demand decoding: The directive **evaluate** requires a direct position on "Evaluate the social consequences of technology diffusion, trade growth and labour hierarchy...", coverage of every clause, evidence-led analysis and a qualified verdict.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For a 20-mark answer, open with a two-sentence thesis; organise six to eight named evidence units as claim -> evidence -> inference -> qualification; reserve the final lines for a graded conclusion.

Why this earns marks: The answer follows the directive, links precise evidence to analysis, acknowledges source or regional limits and closes with a reasoned verdict.

How to improve this answer: For "Evaluate the social consequences of technology diffusion, trade growth and labour hierarchy...", replace the weakest generalisation with one additional named site, text, inscription, coin, ruler or scholarly position and state exactly what that evidence cannot prove.